

jazz and pop music, in what he called “polystylism.” By 1972, he showed his mastery of the technique in his Symphony No. 1, which was the first of his mature works and came as he left the Conservatory to focus on composition. His main income came from composing film scores, but he also embarked on a period of prolific creativity, producing concert music in almost every genre.

However, as he was making his name in Moscow, especially among antiestablishment intellectuals, the authorities took exception to his “un-Soviet” Modernism, and in 1980 he was banned from leaving the country. Nevertheless, thanks to friends who championed his work, including Gidon Kremer, Yuri Bashmet, and Mstislav Rostropovich, he was gaining an international reputation.

The 1980s were a time of change for Schnittke. He began to take an interest in religion, and was baptized in the Catholic Church; his music became more contemplative, even mystical, in a more accessible and consonant style. In 1985, he suffered the first in a series of strokes but he continued to compose, even as his writing became almost illegible. When Soviet president Mikhail Gorbachev introduced the liberalizing policies of glasnost and perestroika, Schnittke was able to leave Moscow, and moved to Hamburg with Irina in 1990. His last work, the Ninth Symphony, was painstakingly deciphered and performed in 1998, shortly before his death.